Good With Children

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52913245.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by Nny11

Summary

Glimmer would tease with a knowing look, “So when are you gonna catch some baby fever, huh?”

“Disgusting.” Catra would sneer, always grateful it sounded like a joke.

“Aww, but you’re so good with them!” Bow would counter.

And she’d smile, maybe flutter her lashes to get a laugh. If they took it as a joke it meant she could say it honestly, “I’m too beautiful for jail.”

Notes

Semi related to my other fic For I Passed Through the Darkness (and I came out singing), but debated back and forth enough that I won't make a series for it just yet.

You don't have to have read that one for this one, but it provides a lot more background information.

See the end of the work for more notes

Sometimes she catches herself in the moment, in the thought. Usually she doesn't.

She's getting so fat.

He's desperate for attention.

They're just causing trouble for fun.

Look at all those little animals, how strange that one day they'll be people.

Someone better train that brat right.

If she does catch herself, she works to let it go right then too. Usually it doesn't work, but Adora almost cried when she saw Catra's scalded hands; she had actually screamed when she found Catra shivering in the tub under a freezing stream of water. How loud and rude and demanding, the awful thought would start, over something so little.

She'd sat outside the playhouse feeling sick as all their little voices melted together begging her to join them; it was shaped like a cartoon dog house. It left her fingers and toes aching from cold in that muggy July heat. Catra smiled in at them and tried to keep her voice from snapping and warbling as she refused. Petunia crawled out wearing a construction paper collar and when Catra ripped it off her her hands twitched to wrap around her thin little throat. If she wants to behave like an animal, I will treat her like one.

Her mother sighed as she stood upright again, kicking half heartedly at the wire door to the kennel. "You can come out when you learn to be human again." When she left the garage she turned off the light, and from inside the house she listened to the nightly news and then a sitcom. She tried to guess which one from the laugh track.

Glimmer would tease with a knowing look, “So when are you gonna catch some baby fever, huh?”

“Disgusting.” Catra would sneer, always grateful it sounded like a joke.

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She didn’t lay a finger on Petunia that day, she’d apologized when her little niece complained, handing it back and warning her not to get a paper cut on her neck. Just like she didn’t do a thing to Angel when he dropped his plate and the cheese-less pizza slice landed sauce first onto her carpet. Just like she didn’t yell at them to shut the **fuck** up when they started singing while she was trying to read. Near misses. All close calls.

“You should celebrate those, they’re victories, you know? You are not the acts you do not commit.”

Her therapist told her that once but it didn’t make much sense to her. Her thoughts are still her, a part of her, in fact, Catra would argue her thoughts were mostly what made her who she was. Maybe she didn’t act on it, but she wanted to, clearly on some level she wanted to.

Adora held her tight and whispered, “It’s okay, I love you.” But it felt like they’d lost some meaning when she refused. Adora wanted a child, wanted to be a mom.

“I never thought I wanted that, it felt shameful to want it. But I do. Could you- can you just give it some thought?”

*Some thought? Give the end of her whole world some **thought** ?? Ha! She already knew Adora’s plans.*

(Catra had frozen at the door, miraculously still holding her keys instead of dropping them from between her numb fingers.

"No! I don't- I don't know! I love her, I don't want to lose her! I d-don't want to leave her over this, but it hurts so much. I always settle and compromise, and I just- fuck I'm being such a bitch. It just hurts, Glimmer!"

She'd walked down the street and then a few blocks over to buy a pack of cigarettes. She let them burn between her fingers without taking a single puff. (Her mother found a lighter in her backpack once during a random search for contraband, and assumed that she'd tried smoking. Weaver had forced her to sit in the bathroom, smoking cigarette after cigarette, until her head pounded and the world almost spun under their weak vent fan. She'd puked before she even finished the first pack.) This one she let burn over and over again, careful not to let them burn her fingers as she walked back home.)

"Yeah, maybe." She'd responded to him, craving a habit she'd never had.

Catra had told Adora no, that she never wanted to have a child-that she was scared of what she'd do to them. Adora's assurances had been nice, and tinged with sadness. But Catra wouldn't crack. She knew that she could keep her shit together for a few days of kid sitting, but a few weeks more and she'd ruin them. Or kill them. Hurt them no matter what.

She made sure to walk on the opposite side of the road from the elementary school on her way to work now, just in case today was the day she would snap. She'd never owned a gun for a damn good reason, she was basically the poster child for gun safety laws.

The worst part was that she was doing better, she really was. She knew these feelings, while constant, weren't consistent. More of a bad thing in passing than her standard reality. It was just hard when she was down at the bottom of the well with them.

It was hard to remember that most days she loved talking with kids because they were so vibrant and bold and unabashed. It felt good to see them unafraid and running free. To remember that the world was actually pretty nice all things considered, and that these awesome kids would become awesome adults some day. Angel had already promised to help Catra learn to pop a wheelie if she ended up in a wheelchair, swearing up and down that he'd paint her chair to look like fire was bursting from the wheels. Petunia had suggested adding roman candles to the handles for flare. Caspian had looked terrified by the thought, and Catra decided that was probably a bad sign for the roman candles. (Too bad too, she'd already been looking forward to lighting them up when people would cut in front of her in line.)

She loved them. She really did! And she protected them fiercely. She just hated that she needed to protect them from herself too.

"I can't." Catra's voice was weak and she wanted to cry as she said it. "I-it's not a good day for it."

"Oh." Scorpia always had this way of expressing disappointment that made Catra want to rip her own throat out. "Hey, it's okay, it happens sometimes. Do you think you'll be up for the park tomorrow?"

She could only picture her own mother's quiet fury as she kneeled down to help Catra use the fountain, whispering harshly about the consequences if this made either of them sick.

"I don't think it's a good idea."

She'd went anyways.

They ooohed and ahhed as she deftly slammed ball after ball into the back of the net, making a game of kicking it back to her. She didn't tell their parents that sometimes she pictured their little faces when she kicked the ball. Mostly she pictured herself. Kicking from further and further back, remembering the pain of how bruises heal and the way her panic had gone calm as she

sank deeper into the pool before a lifeguard jumped in after her while Weaver had only complained afterwards that Catra had embarrassed her.

“You’re just so good with them!” Perfuma had giggled, “When the whole gaggle of them are together it makes me want to climb a wall!”

She’d laughed because it was the polite thing to do. Perfuma hadn’t called her on it because of the same reason.

“Yeah, well, I can’t help it if their worldly experience is lacking but I will take advantage of it.”

“Sure you will.”

She did. She had to. It was the only way to make it work, tricking them into thinking she was a nice and safe adult they could always go to. Catra was sure it wasn’t healthy, but she pretended it was a long con job. That she was an assassin hired to do something, and she had to play nice until she got word to start killing. Sane people didn’t have to do that. They just liked or didn’t like kids. They didn’t have to trick their brains into thinking they’re a good person by pretending to be a bad person. It was fucked up.

“Pleeeease miss Catra? Please!” Caspian was bound to become a movie star someday, but that day was not today.

“No. Have I ever let anyone have more than two candies?”

She had, one time she had let Petunia have a secret third gummy and hadn’t noticed that she served her a smaller portion at dinner until Petunia asked for seconds. She’d held it together just until they left and Adora had consoled her as she cried.

“Nooooo?” They giggled sweetly and tried to look cuter than they already did. “Please?”

It made her hand twitch and chest clench with fury that cooled in microseconds. “No. No one gets a third and that’s final.”

“But without a chocolate, I’ll die!” Caspian’s dramatic declaration was met with laughter from his friends.

(“Oh, so now you know more than me? If you’d stop thinking with your stomach for one night you’d understand how unhealthy it is! Do you want to be fat, hm? Is that what you want? To look like a slob and die young?”

“No ma’am.”

Weaver sighed heavily at the wavering in Catra’s voice. “Oh and here comes the water works. Honestly, you act like I’m being the bad guy here because I care about your health!”

Catra stayed quiet after that, watching her mother’s dinner be eaten and washing the dishes when she’d finished. It was the fourth night of the week without getting food at home, and Catra was not looking forward to the weekend of fasting.)

Catra tilted her head back, forced the bile down, and commanded, “Then perish.”

They squealed with delight and scampered to the television claiming to be a ghost and standing in front of the screen.

She never, ever wanted a kid.

She watched Adora’s wistful smile and misty eyes and swallowed the burning coal in her throat.

“Maybe they should come back next weekend.” She suggested as she turned to finish washing dishes. “Since Angel will be here on Saturday anyway. Might be easier to do a sleepover than arrange pickups.”

Adora leaned against her back, softly kissed the back of her neck, and hummed, “You sure?”

She wanted to turn the water all the way up, hot and full blast and watch the flesh boil off her bones. She wanted to play mario party with them and be a menace just to make them laugh. She wanted to hear them laughing in the other room and she wanted to hurl a glass down onto the rug like a hand grenade as they all screamed joyfully.

When she'd reached down to grab him, she'd meant to yank him roughly. It was a fight against herself to not slap him as he cried, his little finger sluggishly bleeding from the broken ceramic and the pizza squished partially into his sock.

All that anger turned to fear and then a bone deep sadness as she picked him up instead. She understood, she really did. "C'mon little man, let's get that cleaned off and you can pick a bandaid after, okay?"

He sobbed into her shoulder, limp and scared more than anything. Scared just because it had been loud and because his finger hurt. But he held tightly onto her and asked for the one with watermelon slices on it when she put the bandage on.

Adora had already cleaned up the pizza while she'd taken care of Angel, and if Catra didn't know where it had fallen she would never have guessed something hit the floor at all.

God, no. Of course she wasn't sure!

But she knew it would mean a lot to a lot of people, even if she never changed her mind and wanted a kid of her own.

"Yeah, why not?"

"I'll start making the calls then."

Catra turned her head for a kiss and finished the dishes without breaking a single one.

End Notes

Sometimes people who are great with kids still don't want to be parents, and that's okay too.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!